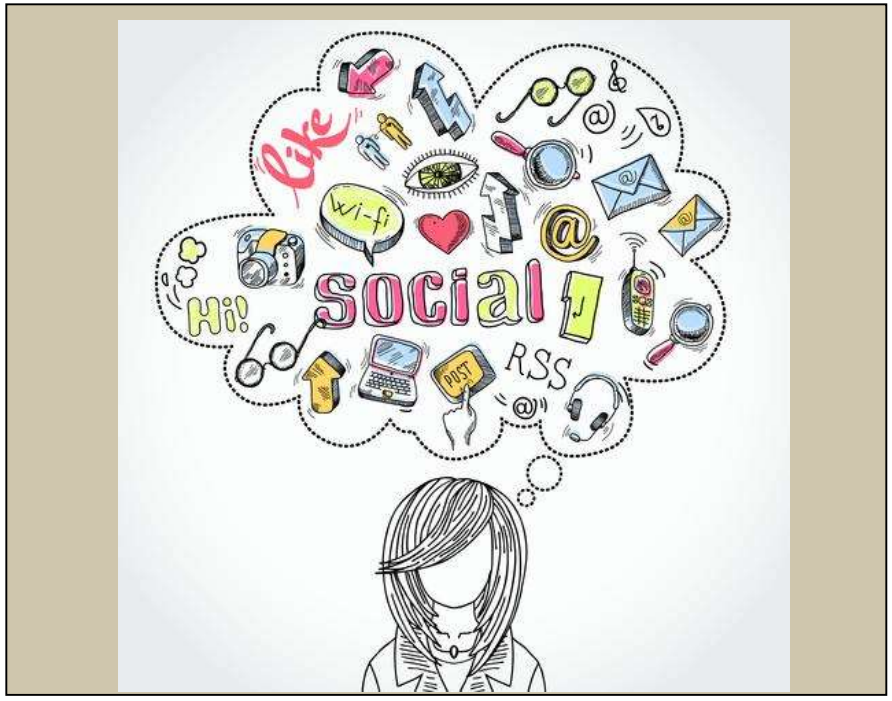
Social Cognition

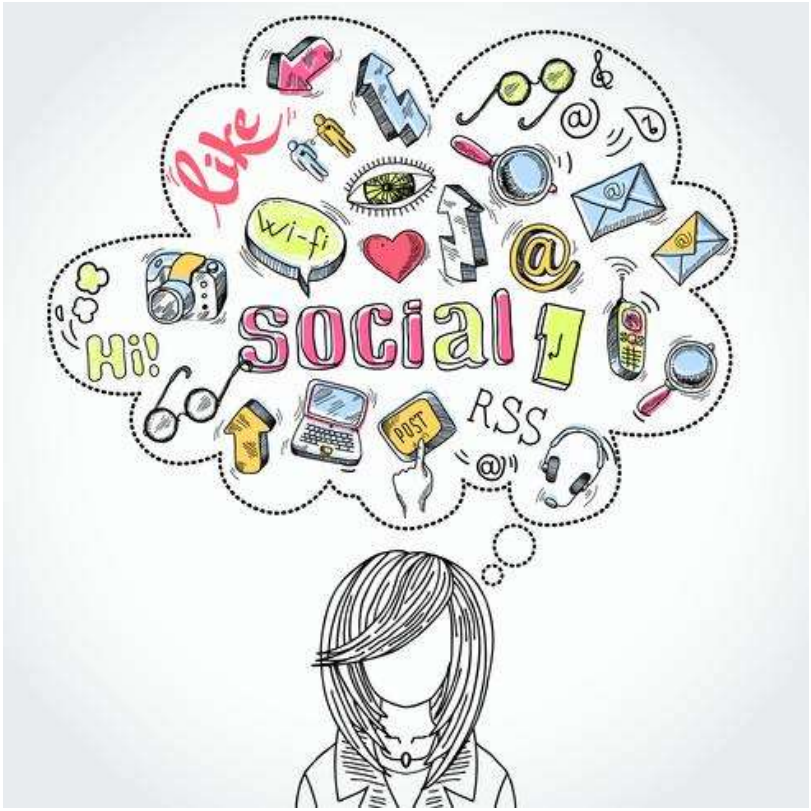
Objectives of chapter 3



- **Role of schemas in social cognition.**
- **Types of mental shortcuts we use.**
- **Errors bias in our social thoughts.**
- **Influence of feelings on our thoughts and vice-versa.**

Social Cognition

How we interpret, analyze and remember information about our social world.



Heuristic

- Mental shortcuts for making decisions.
- Information Overload - a situation when the information for processing is more than the cognitive ability .
- Conditions of uncertainty—where the “correct” answer is difficult to know or would take a great deal of effort to determine.

Types of Heuristic

Representativeness heuristic

Availability heuristic

Anchoring or adjustment heuristic

Representativeness Heuristic

A strategy for making judgments and decisions on the basis of the extent to which current stimulus resembles to other stimuli.

Comparison with prototype

Representativeness Heuristic

Experiment by Tversky and Kahneman

Scenario:

- Linda is 31 yrs, single, outspoken, and very bright.
- She majored in philosophy in college. As a student, she was deeply concerned with discrimination and other social issues, and participated in anti-nuclear demonstrations. Which statement is more likely?
- a. Linda is a bank teller.
- b. Linda is a bank teller and active in the feminist movement.

Representativeness Heuristic

Result:

- Most of you would answer ‘B’, that is ‘Linda is a bank teller and active in the feminist movement.’

- In reality, ‘A’ is more likely than ‘B’.

Availability Heuristic

It refers to the strategy of making judgments on the basis of how easily specific type of information can be brought to mind.

Availability Heuristic

- Tell me some words that starts with ‘K’ & some words in which ‘K’ takes the 3rd place.

Availability Heuristic

Experiment by (Tversky and Kahneman,1974).

- Participants were asked to judge whether letter ‘K’ would appear more frequently at 1st place or 3rd place in all English language words.

- Many answered 1st place.

Anchoring Heuristic

Also known as the adjustment heuristics is a kind of heuristics that influences the way in which people institutively assess probabilities.

Anchoring Heuristic

Experiment by (Tversky and Kahneman)

Scenario:

Kahneman and Tversky asked students to guess the percentage of African nations which are members of the United Nations.

Result:

- One group of students were first asked "Was it more or less than 45%?" whereas other group of students were asked "Was it more or less than 65%?"
- The first group of students guessed lower values than the second group.

Status Quo Heuristic

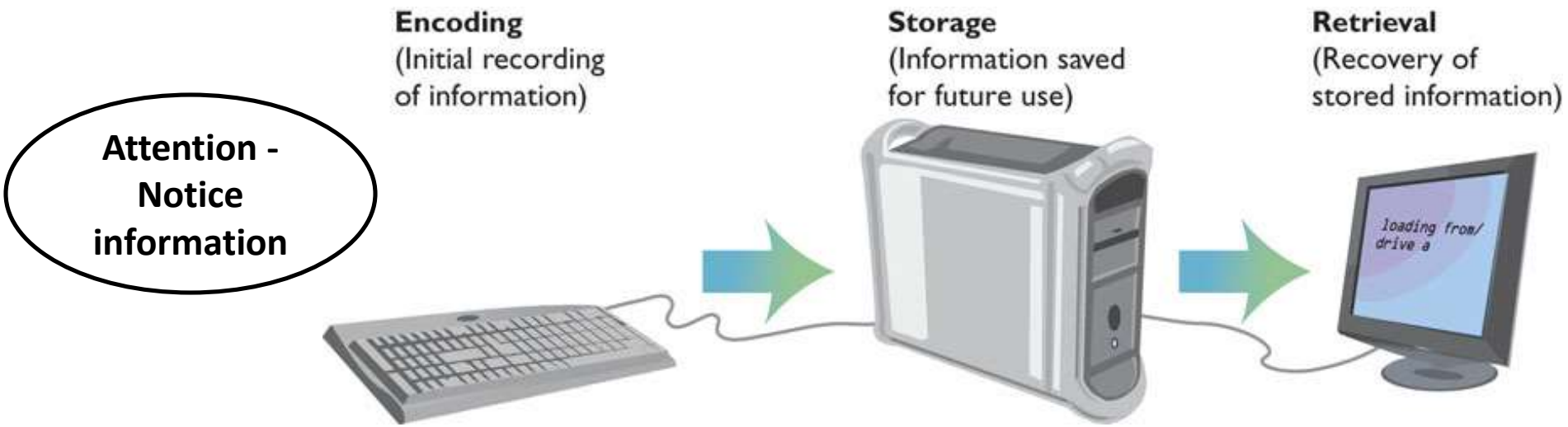
Objects and options that are more easily retrieved from memory may be judged as good," as better than objects and options that are new, rarely encountered.

Schema

Mental framework built around a specific theme that guide processing of social information.

Impact of Schemas on Social Cognition

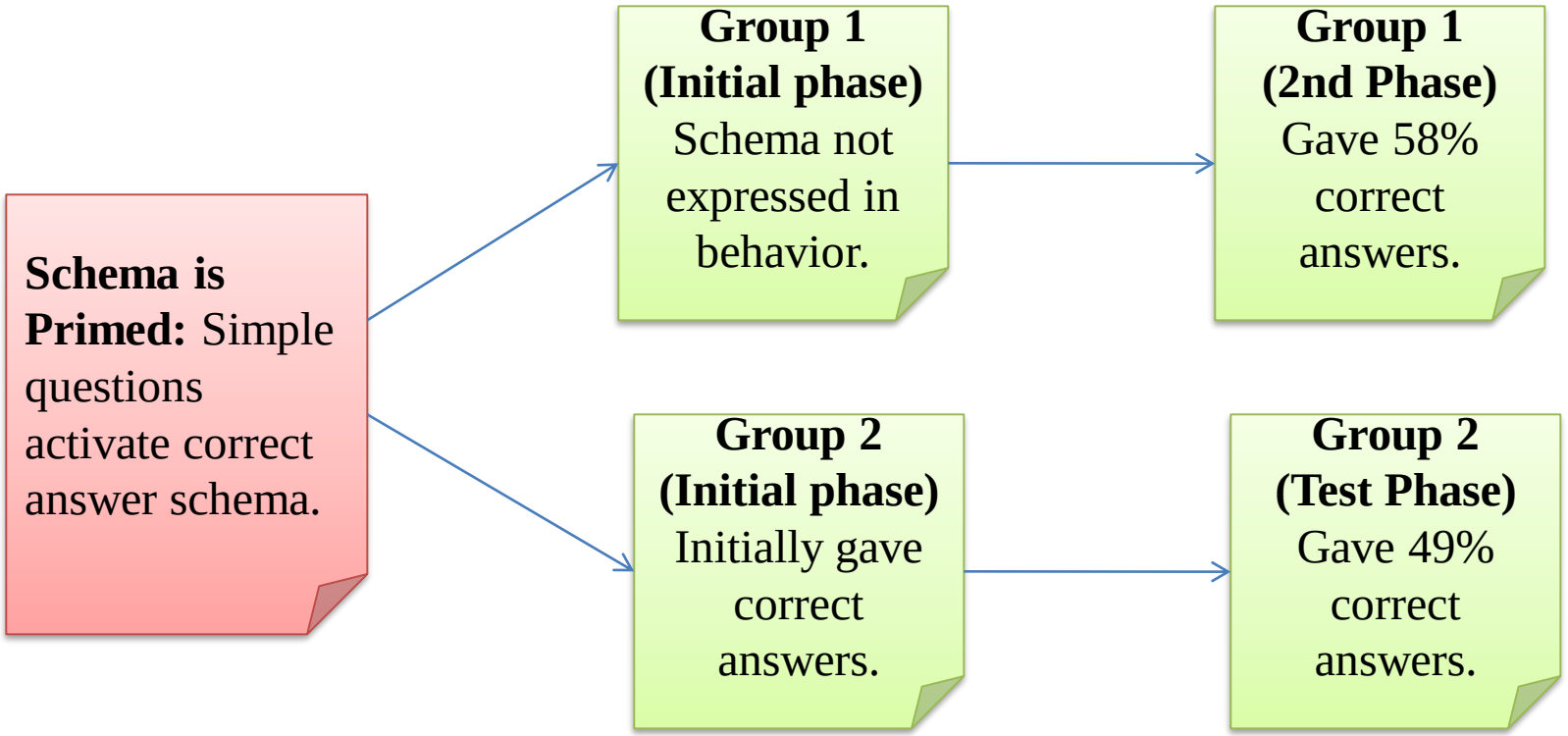
Process by which one encodes, stores, and retrieves information



Which Schemas Guide Our Thought?

Priming : Events or stimulus that increases the availability of the specific type of information in the memory.

Sparrow and Wegner's experiment (2006)



Schema Persistence

Perseverance effect - remaining unchanged even in the face of contradictory information.

Self-fulfilling

Automatic
&
Controlled Processing

Two Basic Models of Social Thought

- **Automatic Processing**

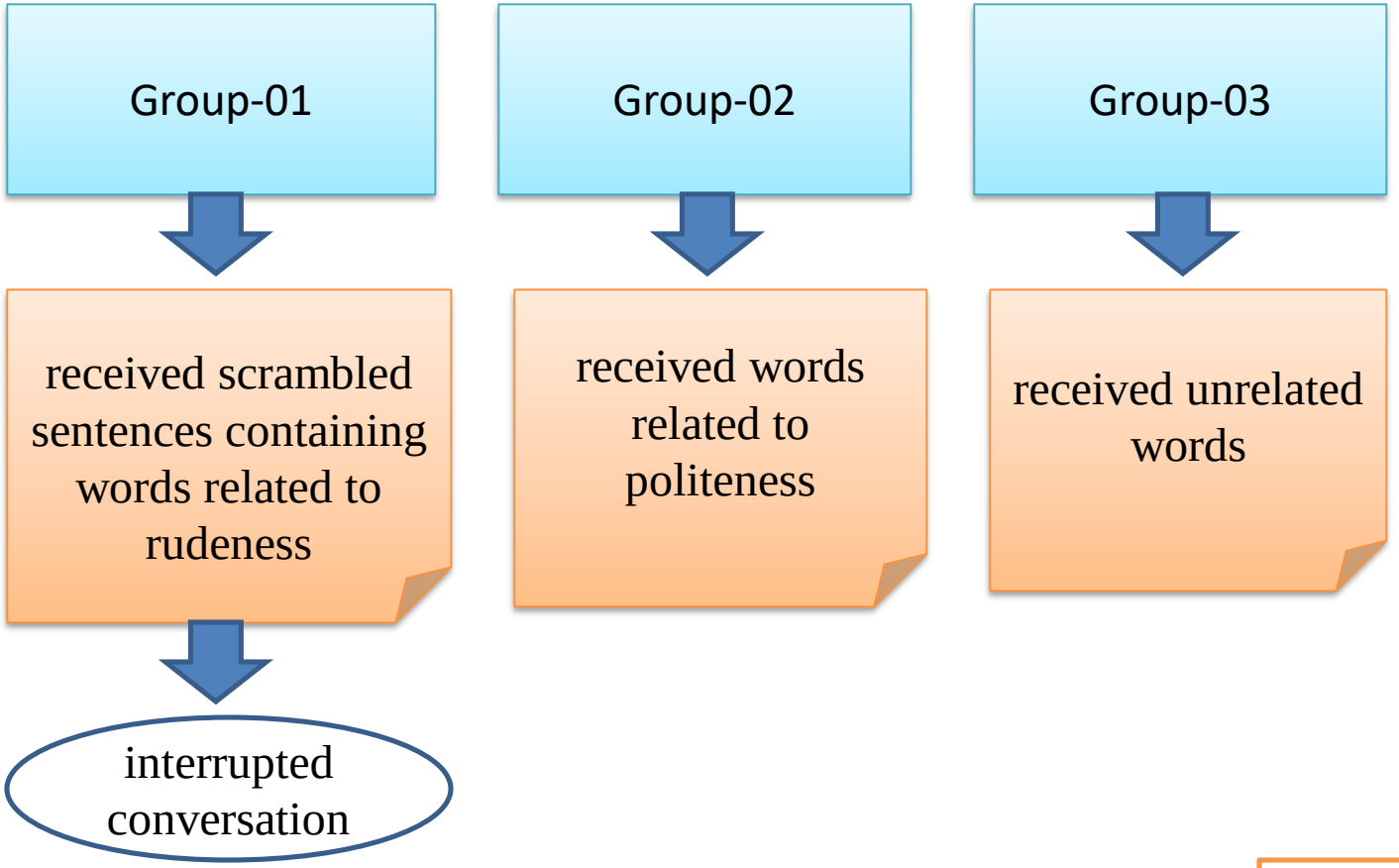
  refers to fast, relatively effortless and intuitive kind processing social information.

- **Controlled Processing**

  refers to the processing of social information in careful, systematic, logical, rational, and effortful way.

Automatic Processing

- Bargh, Chen, and Burrows (1996) conducted an experiment. The impact of rude and polite schema on subject's behavior. These schemas were activated by giving scrambled sentences containing words relevant schema.



Benefits of Automatic Processing

- Dijksterhuis and van Olden (2006).
- They investigated effects information processing on satisfaction with the decision. They looked at posters and indicated their liking.

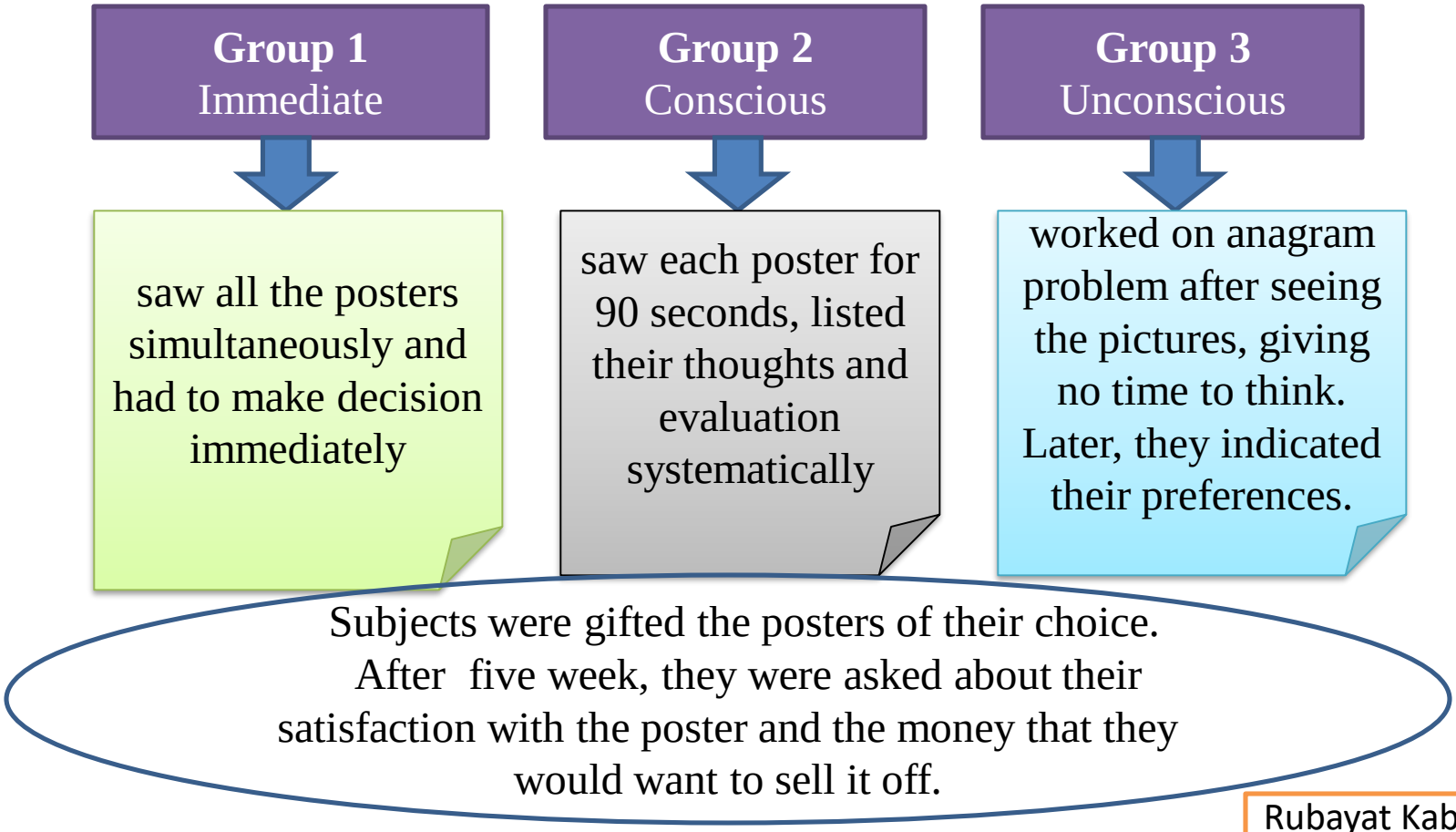
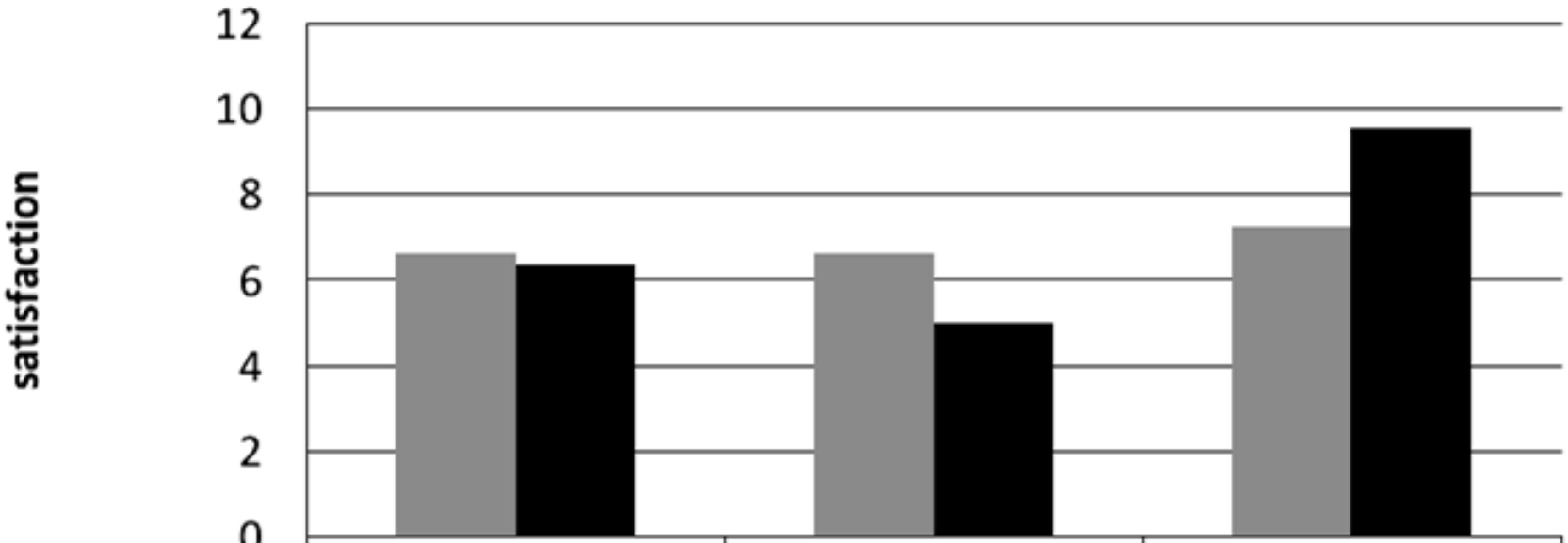


Figure 1: Differences between groups on satifaction and selling price



	Immediate	Conscious	Unconscious
Satisfaction	6.68	6.68	7.3
Selling Price	6.39	5.03	9.59

Potential Sources of Errors in Social Cognition

- **Negativity Bias** the tendency to show greater sensitivity to negative information.

- **The Optimistic Bias** the tendency to expect the overall outcomes as positive.

Potential Sources of Errors in Social Cognition

The Optimistic Bias

Examples are

- **Overconfidence barrier** the tendency to be more confident about the accuracy of our judgments.

- **Planning fallacy** tendency to believe that we can do more work in given period of time than realistically possible.

Potential Sources of Errors in Social Cognition

- **Counterfactual Thinking** It is tendency to imagine other outcomes in the situation than the one's that have occurred.

- **Magical Thinking** involves assumption that does not hold under rational scrutiny.

Potential Sources of Errors in Social Cognition

- **Thought Suppression :** to keep some thought out of their consciousness.

  Thought suppression can be achieved in two stages-

  - **Monitoring Process:** this is an automatic monitoring process, which identifies an unwanted interrupting thought.

  - **Operating Process:** this is an effortful, controlled process to find other important thought to distract from the disturbing thought.

Potential Sources of Errors in Social Cognition

- **Magical Thinking** involves assumption that does not hold under rational scrutiny.

Reference

Text book

- Baron, R.A. & Branscombe, N.R. (2012). *Social Psychology*. (13th ed.). Pearson Education, Inc.